

Questions to ask on a visit

42 questions, drawn from every lesson in the guide. Nobody expects you to ask all of them – take the ones that matter to you. A community that welcomes several of them has already told you something.

01 • WHAT IS AN INTENTIONAL COMMUNITY?

- 01 May I read your agreements? A yes, with an actual document, tells you more than an hour of conversation.
- 02 When were they last reviewed? "We're due a review" is a fine answer. "I'm not sure where they are" is the answer you came for.
- 03 What do you actually hold in common – land, money, decisions, or goodwill? Ask it in those words. Communities that use the term precisely will answer without hesitating.

02 • THE FORMS, TOLD APART

- 04 Which of land, income and decisions do you share – and which do you deliberately not? The second half of that question is the revealing one.
- 05 What would I own, exactly? Ask to be shown the lease, the deed or the share certificate rather than told.
- 06 Who was the last household to leave, and what did they take with them? How a form treats exit tells you more about it than how it describes entry.

03 • WHAT DAILY LIFE ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

- 07 How many hours did you spend in meetings last month? Ask three people. The variance is the answer.
- 08 When did someone last do a job nobody wanted, and who was it? You are listening for a name, and for whether the same name comes up twice.
- 09 What is the most recent thing the community decided that you personally disagreed with? A community where nobody can answer this is either very new or not telling you something.
- 10 Where can I be, here, where nobody can see me? Asked lightly. The answer is usually a place, and sometimes a pause.

04 • HOW COMMUNITIES DECIDE

- 11 Who may block a decision, and on what grounds? If the answer is vague, everything else about their governance is decoration.
- 12 Show me a decision that was reversed. You are testing whether review is real.
- 13 Who facilitated your last meeting, and who facilitated the one before? Two different names is a good sign.
- 14 What happens when someone does not do what they agreed to? The answer is usually the most honest thing you will hear all day.

05 • WHAT JOINING COSTS

- 15 What did the last household who left take with them, and how was that number arrived at? Two questions in one. The second is the real one, and a community that can answer it has a functioning formula rather than a custom.
- 16 What is in the reserve fund, and when was it last reviewed? You are asking whether the low monthly figure is real.
- 17 When did you last raise a special levy, and how much was it? "Never" is a good answer only from a community old enough to have needed one.
- 18 What happens if I cannot pay? Every community has an answer. Some have written it down.

06 • OWNING, LEASING, RENTING

- 19 What exactly would I own – and may I see the document that says so? The lease, the share certificate, the deed. Being shown it is the answer; being told about it is not.
- 20 Who has lent on this before? A community that can name a lender and a household who used it has removed your hardest obstacle. A community that has never had a buyer need finance has not yet tested its own structure.
- 21 Can the resale formula be changed, and by whom? You are asking whether the terms you sign are the terms you keep.
- 22 What happens to this home if I die, and what happens if I stop paying? Two unpleasant questions that a well-run organisation has already written answers to.

07 • MEMBERSHIP: GETTING IN, AND GETTING OUT

- 23 Who has left in the last three years, and why? Ask for numbers and then for stories. A community with no departures in five years is either remarkable or not counting.

- 24 Has anyone ever been asked to leave? What happened? The most uncomfortable question in this guide, and the most informative.
- 25 Who was the last person you turned down, and how did you tell them? You are finding out whether they can say no clearly, which is also how they will treat you.
- 26 What can a provisional member decide, and what can't they? The answer describes how the community thinks about power, in one sentence.
- 27 If I changed my mind at the provisional stage, what would I get back? Ask before you need to know.

08 • CHILDREN, AGEING AND THE SHAPE OF A LIFE

- 28 How many children live here, and how old is the oldest person? Two numbers that describe the community's next twenty years better than anything it says about itself.
- 29 Who has grown old here, and what did the community actually do? Not what it would do. What it did.
- 30 Has a teenager here ever been told off by someone who is not their parent? What happened? You are asking how the culture handles a genuine collision.
- 31 Where would my child be, unsupervised, that an adult can still see? The answer is a place, and it tells you what the site was designed for.
- 32 Has anyone died here? Asked gently, and worth asking.

09 • CONFLICT, POWER AND REPAIR

- 33 When was your conflict process last used? "Never" from a ten-year-old community of forty means it is not usable, not that there has been no conflict.
- 34 Could someone who is not on the board start it? If the answer takes a while, that is the answer.
- 35 Who here would you call if you were in a dispute with a founder? You are testing whether there is anywhere to go that is outside the informal structure.
- 36 What is the last thing the community changed because someone complained? Repair that never changes anything is management.
- 37 Who knows the passwords, the accounts and the boiler? Ask lightly. Note the names, and whether it is the same name three times.

- 38 What nearly ended this place? Nearly every community over ten years old has an answer. One that says "nothing" is either very fortunate or not telling you.
- 39 And what changed afterwards? The real question. A rule, a role, a process – or nothing, in which case it will happen again.
- 40 Who wrote your vision, and when did you last read it out loud? Not whether you have one.
- 41 What would happen here if the three most involved people left in the same year? Watch whether anyone has thought about it before.
- 42 How would this community end, if it decided to? Almost nobody is asked this. The communities that can answer it are, in our experience, the ones least likely to need to.

From the Ultimate Guide to Intentional Communities, as it stood on 7 August 2026. The full guide, with the reasoning behind each question, is free at ecohubs.community/learn/guides/intentional-communities.

Print it, copy it, translate it. If a question here turns out to be the wrong one to ask, we would like to know.